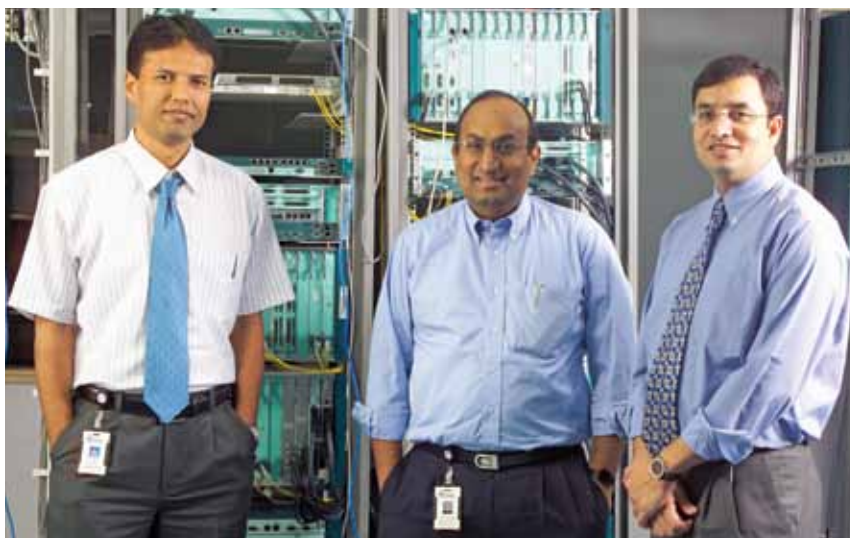




Sanjay Nayak with Co-founders Arnob Roy and Dr Kumar Sivarajan

establishment of Gateway Design Automation in India, which later became Cadence Design Systems in Noida/Delhi, the second of the only two companies involved in deep tech product development in India, along with Texas Instruments in Bengaluru during the 1980's.

"It was a time when the exhaustive coursework of electronic design automation and VLSI did not exist in most IITs or other colleges. We ended up helping set up coursework at IIT Kanpur and IIT Delhi to train students in this field, and worked with other educational institutes to give them the latest trends in semiconductors and EDA. We also had training courses and engaged on projects with faculty," he recalls.

The family man

Along with laying the foundational stones of the electronics ecosystem, Sanjay started building a life with Anju, in 1989. "I have been very lucky to have her as my wife. To support my ambitions and dreams, she chose to be a homemaker, all her life, despite having a masters' in economics," he shares. The couple has two sons—Shravan and Anmol—who are now 31 and 29. Both have followed

in the footsteps of their father and taken up engineering as a profession.

Growing up, Sanjay's mother, a traditional homemaker, made sure that her children were instilled with spiritual values. "My mother always kept the family together and instilled strong values in us." Leaning on the same values, Sanjay always made family his priority.

After a brief stint of two years in the US from 1995-1997, Sanjay decided to move back to India in 1997 and founded Viewlogic India, which was later acquired by Synopsys India, where he served as the managing director. The first thing he did after moving to Bengaluru was to buy a house in Koramangala, near the local club to gain access to tennis, swimming, and all kinds of sports. "Sports as a lifestyle was instilled right from the start, and I wanted my kids to adopt it as well. Every morning, I would walk to the club to play tennis, and my kids used all the club facilities as well," he shares.

Proud of his boarding school heritage, Sanjay wanted his children to gain the same exposure as he did and made it a point to travel extensively together. A strict vegetarian,

a lifestyle passed down from his parents, Sanjay and his family enjoy various global cuisines, his favourite being Italian and Thai.

"Despite being in a startup and having a very intense job with lots of business travel, I don't think there was ever an instance when my children wanted me to be with them, and I wasn't there. It all boils down to prioritisation and efficient time management," he says.

For Sanjay, parenting has been less about giving instructions and more about setting an example. "I have let them observe and learn from experience, because actions speak louder than words. Children emulate what they see and internalise the value system around them without any lectures," he says.

Controlling the controllables

From a boy who couldn't get into IIT, to an industry leader who helped design the electronics curriculum for IITs and other leading engineering institutions in India, Sanjay Nayak has not just created an example for his children, but also every engineer who aspires to take on the world.

Be it unconventional choices like beginning his career in a startup in the US instead of any big MNC, or coming back to India after studying in the US, to leaving his cush job as MD at Synopsys to jump back into the startup life—Sanjay Nayak has never said no to a challenge.

"I was very comfortable at Synopsys but, somehow, I was craving adventure and felt that I needed to do something on my own to fully realise my potential. I wanted to do something path breaking that could set an example for building a deep-tech product company from India. The startup life was beckoning me. That is when I met my second role model, Dr Gururaj 'Desh' Deshpande, a successful serial entrepreneur," he recounts as his eyes light up with admiration